



New Zealand

Lying in the South Pacific, 990 miles (1600 km) southeast of Australia, New Zealand comprises North and South Islands, separated by the Cook Strait, and many smaller islands.



GEOGRAPHY

North Island, noted for hot springs and geysers, has the bulk of the population. South Island is mostly mountainous, with eastern lowlands.



CLIMATE

Generally temperate and damp. The far north is almost subtropical, whereas southern winters are cold.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Maoris were the first settlers, 1200 years ago. Today's majority European population is descended mainly from British migrants who settled after 1840. Maoris' living and education standards are generally lower than average. The government is continuing to negotiate the settlement of Maori land claims.



INSIGHT: *New Zealand women were the first to get the vote (1893)*



THE ECONOMY

Tourism is the biggest foreign-exchange earner. Modern agricultural sector; world's top exporter of dairy products. Hi-tech manufacturing. Open economy. Strong trade links.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: New Zealand

DATE OF FORMATION: 1947

CAPITAL: Wellington

POPULATION: 4.27 million

TOTAL AREA: 103,737 sq. miles
(268,680 sq. km)

DENSITY: 41 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Maori*

RELIGIONS: Anglican 24%, other 22%,
Presbyterian 18%, nonreligious 16%,
Roman Catholic 15%, Methodist 5%

ETHNIC MIX: European 75%, Maori 15%,
other 7%, Samoan 3%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: New Zealand dollar = 100 cents